LIFESTYLE · CULTURE · CREATIVE ECONOMY

# SEOUL cult

ISSUE 01/2026

## SEOUL'S BRAVE RETAIL

## TRAVEL TO BE SOMEONE NEW

## OLIVE YOUNG'S WELLNESS BET

## HEATHERWICK STUDIO IN SEOUL

COVER PHOTOGRAPHY SONIA BROWN

Digital Edition

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# LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

Seoul became my new hometown in 2008. Back then, a lot of people in Europe couldn't even point out Seoul on a map.

In recent years, those of us who have lived our whole lives, or large parts of our lives here, have watched the city's global fame grow.

I recently rewatched a show about Seoul that I co-produced with a team from SVT, the Swedish national television, in 2012. The way I describe Seoul in that show still stands: A year holds so much more in Seoul than anywhere else; in the middle of the speed, there are temples, markets, and palaces that make time stand still; the city stays up late, office buildings are often lit up after midnight, and bars are open any day of the week.

Addictive, perhaps. Something like a complicated love story, most certainly. An intense sense of aliveness, for sure.

"Addictive, perh
complicated lov
An intense sens

Now, Seoul seems to be on everyone's travel bucket list.

With Seoul Cult, we want to invite you to our city, our home. Deep into the culture and the society, curate what is beautiful, delicious, cool, interesting, and new. Guide you through the complicated and the speed, far from algorithms and tell you stories from this incredible city.

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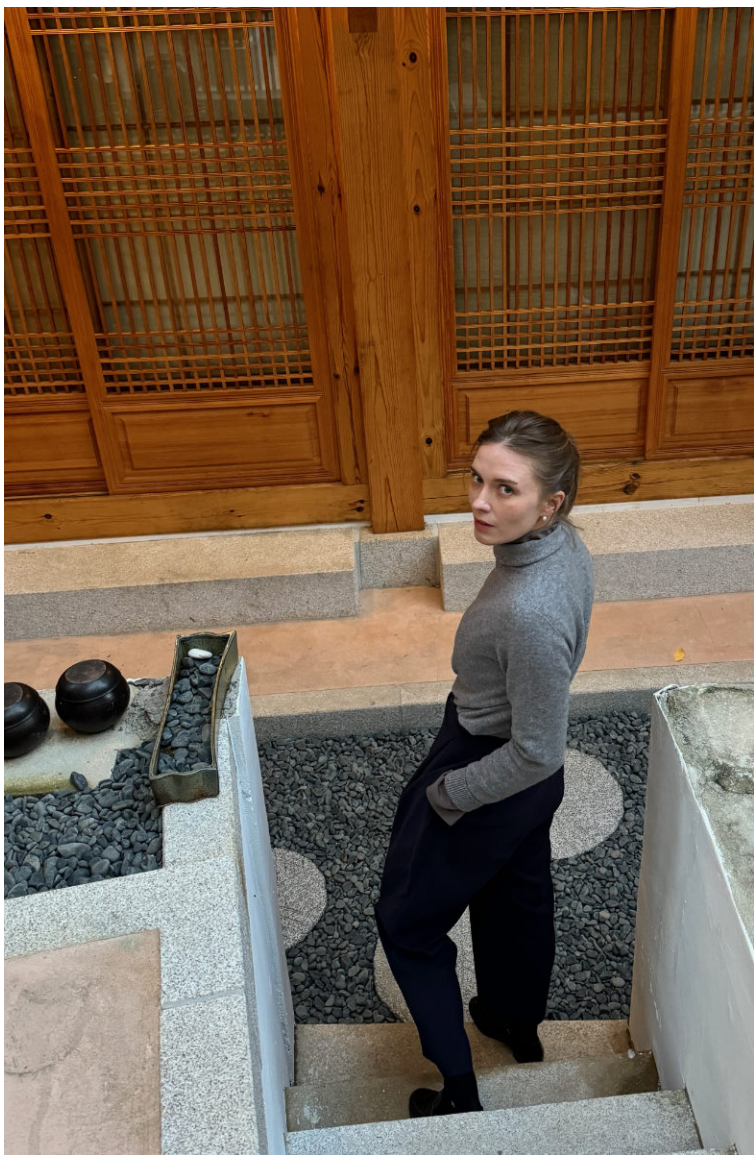
se of aliveness, for sure."

IDA KYMMER, EDITOR IN CHIEF



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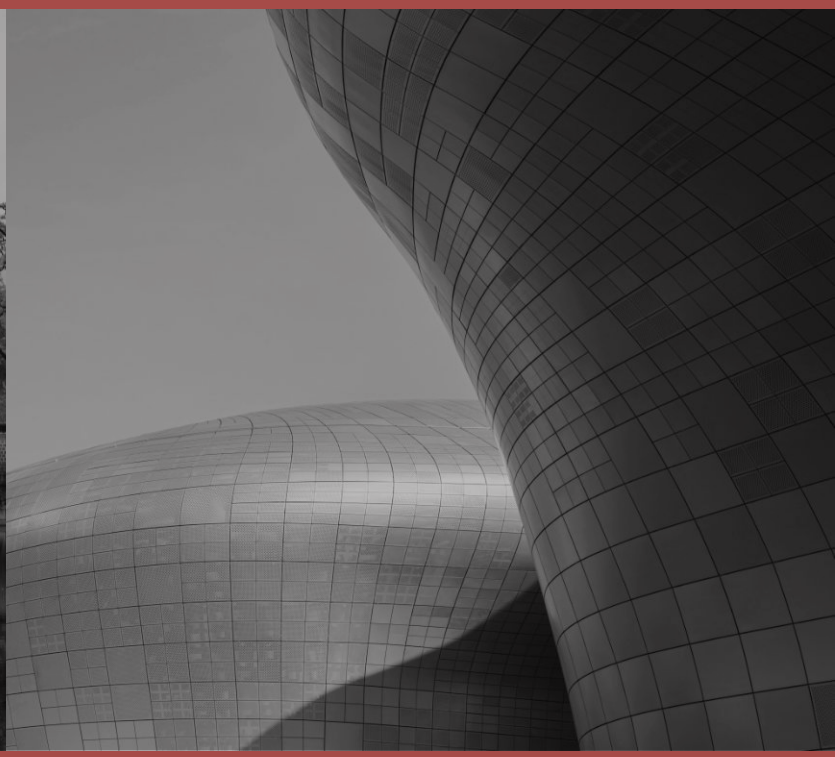

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# BRAVE SEOUL RETAIL

Sonia Brown, executive Creative Director at Quadrant Design and photographer travels to Seoul to experience its vibrant retail scene.

**PHOTOGRAPHY Sonia Brown**

“There is a real kind of bravery around Seoul, and I absolutely fell in love with it,” says Sonia Brown, Executive Director and Head of Design at Quadrant Design in London. For 17 years, she has been a retail designer, working with high-street and luxury brands across retail and restaurants.

Sonia was always a big fan of New York. Apart from scouring the internet, magazines, and blogs for new inspiration, she kept going back to New York every single year. But then, about 8 years ago, Seoul started showing up on blogs and in magazines. The new ways of doing things piqued Sonia's curiosity.

Last year in October, Sonia visited Seoul for the first time.

“All those images that I’ve seen and collected over the years, I can now understand them so much more,” she says.

Over a few days, she visited retail stores in Seongsu, Sinsa, Gangnam, Hannam, and Bukcheon to experience Seoul's retail scene. With her, she had her Sony A9. Alongside her career in retail design, she has been running a photography business with her husband, specialising in wedding photography.

## “Whenever we can feel a moment of awe as a human being, it captivates us, doesn’t it?”

“I love capturing those real moments between people and places,” she says. Sonia always uses a 35mm lens for that exact reason — it is the closest to what we see through our own eyes.

“For me, photography is the same as what I’m creating for a brand,” she explains. “My love is to understand what kind of stories are told, what authentic touches there are that create a brand’s vision. It’s the same with photography. My style is very much finding the honesty in photos.”

The first retail space Sonia visited was Tambourins in Seongsu. The flagship store features a concrete shell with a contemporary glass structure in the centre.

“They’re using all this real estate as a shell essentially,” Sonia says. It is only when you enter and go down to the basement that the retail space opens up, revealing a mushroom that has sounds, steam, smoke and scent.

H&M'S FASHION SPACE IN SEONGSU

TAMBURINS FLAGSHIP STORE IN SEONGSU

“It’s unseen to the public until you go down there. There is a huge bravery in that.” Sonia says.

The experience took Sonia’s breath away.

“Whenever we can feel a moment of awe as a human being, it captivates us, doesn’t it?”

It was not only the local brands that fascinated Sonia during her visit. H&M, a brand with which Sonia has experience in the UK, has a space in Seongsu that really stood out to her.

“They have used their brand identity by focusing on the red – using it in a strong, powerful and colour-blocking way,” she explains. The store has also flipped the typical store design rules by placing the fitting room in the centre of the space instead of tucking it away.

“Seeing it executed in such a way just felt really brave,” Sonia says.

Perfumer H, a British brand with a shop in Dosan, also fascinated Sonia.

## "There is a kind of artistic licence to do anything.”

“It felt so different from their UK shops – it was welcoming, not intimidating as many high-end shops can be,” she says. She feels that in Seoul, barriers are being broken down through the staff.

“People we met in Korea were more hosts than sales assistants, and there was a sense of hospitality and welcoming,” she remembers.

Next to Perfumer H’s store, they have something called Bath House – a timber-constructed box, made out of cedar wood. Sonia was invited in, and the staff closed the door.

“I was engulfed in the scent of cedar. All natural, real.”

Superbrands come to Seoul to test. It’s completely unlike Europe and the UK, which are very restrictive. In Seoul, you can be anything.

“A brand can come to Seoul and do whatever they want; there is a kind of artistic licence to do anything,” Sonia says. “Something that doesn’t exist elsewhere.”

KODAK'S SEONGSU STORE

In Seoul, part of the store is dedicated to brand stories and experiences, making people spend more time in the store, have a better experience, and feel a connection to the brand.

"The brands are not filling this amazing vessel of space with just lines and lines of stock and making it all about selling," Sonia explains.

In ADERERROR's space in Sinsa, she discovered that lots of recycled materials were used in interesting ways. Old, carved, monolithic slabs were used to showcase products, and the fittings were often just as beautiful as the products, whereas it is usually about elevating the product and letting the fixtures blend into the background. Here, the fixture becomes an art installation.

"The retail spaces are where people connect and fall in love with the brands. The sales happen later, maybe at another store or online," Sonia comments.

"It is the canvas to connect with their people and their tribes."

Sonia wants to show clients that retail spaces can hold a different value. It doesn't have to fit 200 pairs of jeans; it can be 20 pairs with more space to express the brand, in the long run creating more value.

## "It's a bit like a rite of passage. It is an aspirational city to visit."

"Seoul made me feel confident to push our clients to trust, to be brave and to say that there is a better, more clever way of doing things."

Since her visit to Seoul, clients and colleagues have been fascinated by the stories she has shared about Seoul and her experience there.

"It's a bit like a rite of passage," she says. "It is an aspirational city to visit."

ADER ERROR SINSA STORE

# SONIA'S SEOUL RETAIL MUST-VISITS

**SEONGSU**
Point of View
Tamburins
H&M
Deus Ex Machina
Christian Dior
Kodak store
Jellycat space
Haus Nowhere
ECP

**CHEONGDAM / APGUJEONG RODEO**

Birkenstock
Louis Vuitton
10 Corso Como
BOONTHESHOP
Acne Studios

**SINSA**
Hyundai Motorstudio

**DOSAN PARK**
Haus Dosan

**GAROSU-GIL**
ADERERROR

**HANNAM**
Comme des Garçons
Atelier Pond
Aigle pop-up

**SONIA BROWN** is Executive Creative Director at Quadrant Design, with 17 years of experience across retail, hospitality and workplace design.

Known for translating brand identity into distinctive physical environments, she has collaborated with Rolex, Watches of Switzerland, Harrods, Eton Shirts, Topshop, EL&N London, Havaianas and Beats by Dre.

Alongside her design practice, Sonia is a photographer — co-founding a wedding photography business in 2014, recognised in British Vogue, and today documenting travel and the places that shape her creative perspective.

**QUADRANT DESIGN** quadrantdesign.co.uk
**RS BROWN PHOTOGRAPHY** rsbrownphotography.com

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PATISSERIE
ARMONI

K-pop, K-dramas, and K-beauty have led to a drastic change in why people visit Seoul, and what they do during their stay.

# BECOMING SEOUL

IMAGE FROM SEOUL TOURISM ARCHIVE

Seoul has become the world's favourite city for self-reinvention. Tourists are arriving in record numbers: 18.9 million in 2025 - the highest in South Korea's history — and for the most part, they are not here to tick something off a list. They are here to try something on: a new skin routine, a wardrobe, a lifestyle, an identity. The sightseeing still happens, but is almost incidental. What people are really booking when they book a flight to Seoul is a rehearsal for a version of themselves they have been watching on a screen.

## TOURISM TO THE DAILY LIVES OF KOREANS

Visitors' itineraries are often fully packed with skin & scalp analysis, colour analysis, vision correction, dermatological procedures, body scrubs, Olive Young hauls, and a more varied kind of Korean cusising than ever before. They go to dance classes: in Seongdong studios, foreign nationals account for 70% of the beginner hobby classes, and credit card data processed by the Korea Tourism Data Lab shows they love Noraebang — the foreign tourists' spending has increased by 54.8% year-on-year.

Creatrip, a Korean travel platform targeting foreign tourists, calls this the 'K-dive' trend in their 2025 inbound tourism report. "Now, foreign tourists want not just to visit Korea but to go deep into the daily lives of Koreans," Im Hye-min, CEO of Creatrip, told Sports Kyunghyang.

Many visitors follow a standardised itinerary that independent travellers — discovered on the TikTok platform, refined on Xiohongshu — follow almost identically across the city. It is part self-improvement program, part content shoot, part cultural immersion.

For many, it begins at the jjimjilbang, best within hours of landing. There, they get a full-body scrub beside locals who have been doing this every Saturday since childhood. The next morning, the queue forms outside Olive Young in Seongsu by 8:30 am — for a free skin analysis and a bag of products calibrated to a specific face in a particular climate. Then the dance class, the colour analysis, the dermatology consultation. Each site is documented, posted, and watched by the next person, who builds their own itinerary.

## K-CONTENT CREATES DESIRE

K-pop, K-drama, and K-beauty have peaked over the past few years. This kind of content and beauty products create a desire for a specific experience, to feel something, to belong to something -- and that desire translates not only into booked flights but into what people do when they arrive in Korea.

The Korea Institute of Public Finance has found that a 1% increase in domestic broadcasting program exports is associated with a 0.176% increase in foreign tourists. A 1% increase in K-pop album exports drives a 0.074% increase.

A great example of this is the release of K-pop Demon Hunters, now Netflix's most-watched film ever, with 325 million views and two Oscar nominations. After the release, arrivals shifted from mainly Asian to a greater share from Western countries. In 2025, American arrivals to Korea are up 44% on pre-COVID levels. European arrivals are up 19%. Oceanian arrivals are up 51%. Western Airlines is following the trend by adding and extending nonstop routes, often in wide-body Dreamliners. When Alaska Airlines departed from Seattle, Andrew Choi, the voice behind the lead character in K-pop Demon Hunter, was at the gate to wish everyone a safe and comfortable flight.

> "Now, foreign tourists want not just to visit Korea but to go deep into the daily lives of Koreans."

Numbers from the Korean Tourism Organisation show a jump from 32.1% in 2023 to 41.8% in 2025 in the share of tourists citing K-content as their primary motivation for visiting.

Many start trying to access the Korean life already at home. In the US, Duolingo saw a 22% increase in the number of Korean learners in a single year. University Korean enrollment

IMAGE FROM SEOUL TOURISM ARCHIVE

spiked by 38% — the sharpest rise of any foreign language — while overall foreign language study fell by 16%.

The content not only creates desire for a place, but it also creates desire for a person, or rather, an idea of a person. On January 1, 2026, Netflix Brazil launched My Korean Boyfriend — the first Brazilian reality production ever filmed in South Korea. It follows five Brazilian women in long-distance relationships as they travel to Seoul to find out whether life in Korea really lives up to the K-drama hype. The trailer opens with one cast member asking the question that becomes the whole premise: "We travelled across the world to find out if K-dramas exist in real life."

CEO Kil Ki-yeon appointed BLANKPINK's Jennie as Seoul's 2025 honorary ambassador. The "Absolutely in Seoul" campaign was broadcast across NBC Universal's global network and outdoor screens across the US and Australia, and received over 600 million views within its first month.

"Our ultimate goal is for visitors to stay longer, experience more deeply and finally become a global fandom with a strong attachment to the Seoul brand," said Kil Ki-yeon, CEO of the Seoul Tourism Organization.

Seoul's Mayor, Oh Se-hoon, a 62-year-old former lawyer, is on a mission to pitch Seoul less as a destination rather than as a proposition. His argument, made consistently from New York to Singapore, is that the cities that win the next century will not be the ones with the lowest tax rates or the best startup incentives. They will be the ones people actually want to live in.

**"2030 is too late. We will achieve the 30 million visitor milestone by 2028."**

The hashtag #gukjecouple — gukje meaning "international" — is attached to more than 34,000 YouTube videos, most of which document the cultural negotiations in relationships between Westerners and Koreans.

## THE 3.3.7.7 STRATEGY

The Seoul Tourism Organization has a strong understanding of the relationship between content, desire, and visitor numbers. In 2025, STO's

"To make a city business-friendly, people talk about lowering the tax rate or revitalising the startup ecosystem. But that's obvious. To become a truly

business–friendly city, we need to make a city that is very attractive, where people want to live, make money, and enjoy themselves."

Seoul has put in place the 3.3.7.7 strategy — named for its core targets — which aims to double everything: 30 million annual inbound tourists, each spending 3 million Korean won, staying 7 days, with a 70% revisit rate.

"2030 is too late. We will achieve the 30 million visitor milestone by 2028." That means an annual growth of more than 16% "bold but necessary," says Korea Tourism Organization's President Park Sung Hyeuck, a marketing executive recruited from Samsung's advertising arm, Cheil Worldwide:

"Numbers are important, but how long visitors stay and how much they consume defines true success." He wants tourism to sit alongside automobiles and semiconductors as one of Korea's three major export industries within three years.

K-POP DEMON HUNTER HAS MORE THAN

**500 MILLION VIEWES**

ON NETFLIX

**18.9 MILLION**

TOURISTS VISITED KOREA IN 2025

**U.S. ARRIVALS UP BY 44%**

COMPARED TO PRE-COVID LEVELS

**41% VISIT BECAUSE OF K-CONTENT**

**38% JUMP IN KOREAN**

UNIVERSITY ENROLLMENT IN THE US - WHILE OVERALL FOREIGN LANGUAGE STUDY FELL 16%

# LINK SEOUL
# TALCHUM

Bongsan Talchum — National Intangible Heritage No. 17 from Hwanghae Province — is part of Korea's mask dance tradition, which always includes an element of provocation and satire and is performed in public.

Link Seoul's EP:2, TALCHUM, does exactly this: it doesn't treat the tradition as an artefact to be carefully handled. It treats it as a living argument that still has something to say.

The production is structured in two halves that don't so much contrast as interrogate each other. The first stages, Bongsan Talchum in its traditional form — the Old Monk, Somu, Chwibari, Meokjung, the Groom, the Lion — each full of desire

. EP:2,

Link Seoul's EP:2, TALCHUM is directed by Yoo Su-kyung, founder of COREO, Korea's first dedicated dance label.

Conversations are already underway for future performances at the Korean Cultural Centre UK in London and the Musée Guimet in Paris.

EP:1, GAT: Reinterpreting Tradition, in the form of an exhibiton, took place in August 2025. Gatiljang is the traditional Korean craft of hat-making. This episode introduced its historical background and significance. The exhibition showcased pieces by young artists who have reinterpreted the gatil master's traditions with a contemporary sensibility.

EP:3 details are yet to be announced, but the current category is set to craft, and it will be a hands-on, participatory direction — in line with the episodes Link Seoul has presented previously.

**LINK SEOUL linkseoul.kr**

All photographs provided by Link Seoul

# ALL LIVE BETTER

**In 2026, Olive Young is betting on Wellness and Global Expansion.**

At lunchtime in Seoul's bustling Gwangwhamun district, shoppers wait behind a velvet rope to enter CJ Olive Young's new wellness store, Olive Better. Inside, visitors browse a curated selection of wellness products supporting mindful, daily routines—including inner-beauty foods, nutritional supplements, fitness gear, aromatherapy, dermacosmetics, sleep enhancers, and oral-care essentials.

The shop, which opened on January 30 in D-Tower, spans over 430 square meters across two floors and stocks around 3,000 products from over 500 brands. The location was deliberately chosen for its context: Gwangwhamun is a high-traffic business district surrounded by yoga studios and gyms. In line with Olive Young's new strategy, the store is intended to slot into a working day rather than require a detour from it, expressing the belief that wellness should fit real life, not demand a lifestyle change.

> Wellness should fit real life,
> not demand a lifestyle change.

"While the global wellness market has continued to grow since COVID-19, offline touchpoints that provide personalised recommendations and hands-on experiences remain limited," an

OLIVE BETTER
AND
ENING
FLOOR GUIDE

Olive Young spokesperson comments in a press release published on the company's homepage.

A second Olive Better store is planned near Gangnam Station in the first half of 2026, with further expansion across Seoul's major commercial areas to follow. The concept is already integrated into an App-in-App platform within the existing Olive Young app, which offers personalised wellness recommendations and routine reminders based on individual user profiles.

Lee Dong-geun, Head of New Growth Retail Business, has described the aim as lowering the entry barriers to wellness — making it available, daily, and genuinely useful, rather than aspirational or intimidating.

Each year, Olive Young publishes a trend keyword that attempts to name the cultural moment. For 2026, that word is FULLMOON. It describes a movement toward wholeness—a desire to care not only about how you look, but also about how you feel, sleep, move, recover, and eat. The company explains that FULLMOON is an acronym for focus, uncover, listen, lifestyle, mindful, optimise, original, and nourish, describing key elements Olive Young believes will define health and beauty for the next generation.

> **A movement towards wholeness – a desire to care for how you feel, sleep, move, recover, and eat.**

In January, Olive Young also announced a global strategic partnership with Sephora, introducing dedicated K-beauty zones curated by Olive Young to be rolled out across Sephora's online and offline channels. These K-beauty zones will launch in fall 2026 across approximately 700 Sephora locations in the US and Canada, as well as in major Asian markets including

Hong Kong SAR, Singapore, Malaysia, and Thailand. Expansion into the Middle East, the UK, and Australia will follow in 2027. Notably, Sephora entered South Korea in 2019 and exited in 2024, unable to compete with Olive Young's market dominance, store density, and cultural fluency.

Each store will offer a carefully chosen selection of Korean beauty and wellness products, alongside local US brands.

**FEEL-GOOD WELLNESS** moving into daily diet and nutrition — easy, routine-friendly formats that fit real life

**UNWIND TO WIN SLEEP AND RECOVERY** as a daily advantage — shaping routines, categories, and demand worldwide

**LIFESTYLE SHIFT** (climate) extreme heat and unpredictable winters driving 'survival routines' that reshape what counts as an essential

**LAYERED K-ROUTINE** k-beauty shifting from trend to daily habit — moving beyond hero products into layered, personalised, multi-category routines

**MEDICAL-HOME LOOP** daily skincare, in-office procedures, and post-treatment recovery forming one continuous loop

**OVER THE MAKEUP** consumers expecting makeup to actively support skin condition — wearing it feels like part of the skincare routine

**ONE-BITE LUXURY** luxury becoming approachable through smaller formats — sampling premium, collecting what fits your identity

**NEXT-GEN BEAUTY CONCIERGE** ai shifting from search to conversation — understanding context and building personalised routines around goals

# STRUCTUR
# CULTURE

At Seoul Fashion Week F/W 2026, hosted on 2-8 February, designers showed tailored structures, play with soft materials, furs and frills, and strong references to Korean culture.

YUNGADANG

PHENOMENON SEEPER

# E AND

YUNGADANG

DOUCAN

DOUCAN

DOUCAN

DAILY MIRROR

DAILY MIRROR

HANNAH SHIN

HOLYNUMBER7

All photographs provided by the designers

Heatherwick Studio headed the 5th Seoul Biennale of Architecture and Urbanism in 2025 and has since then won projects such as Nodeul Island, Hanwha Galleria, the COEX Convention and Exhibition Centre, and residential redevelopments in Daegyo and Apgujeong. They are on the lookout to contribute with a more human approach to urban development.

# A RADICAL
# HUMAN SE

FACADE
FACADE-ISH LAB(OR)S
OUR HAGWON
THE CREATIVE COMMUNITIES
WELCOME

LY MORE
OUL

Radically More Human, reads a statement in Korean and English on a large wall in Songhyeon Green Plaza in central Seoul. The wall is 90 metres long, 4 storeys high and twists in the middle. It is made from 1,428 steel tiles, and features 400 buildings from 38 countries, as well as inscriptions by citizens, scientists, and designers. Heatherwick Studio constructed the piece for the 5th Seoul Biennale of Architecture and Urbanism, which the studio also headed, held in Seoul from September to November 2025.

"Seoul is rapidly emerging from a period which delivered economically but left people surrounded by a city that could feel lonely, intense, and in constant flux," says Matt Bell, Strategic Communications Director at the Studio.

While preparing to head the biennale, the Studio researched people's relationships to buildings in Seoul: 90% said that how buildings look affects how they feel, and 97% described apartment complexes as soulless and suffocating. At the same time, 48% of people said they're willing to get involved and take action.

"There's a real thirst to create more emotionally resonant architecture and a better quality of life; and much to its credit, Seoul has the confidence to have this conversation in a way that a lot of cities don't," says Matt.

## HEATHERWICK STUDIO IN SEOUL

Heatherwick Studio's work in Seoul really took off after an exhibition at the Culture Station curated by Mami Kataoka of the MORI Art Museum in 2023. The exhibition explored soulfulness:

"We wanted to show how the craft and detail that artisans bring to small objects could also be applied to buildings and big bits of city," says Matt. Nearly 60,000 visitors came, and after that, the Studio won the public competition to redesign Nodeul Island, and other projects followed, such as the Hanwha Galleria, the COEX Convention and Exhibition Centre, and residential redevelopments in Daegyo and Apgujeong.

"All of them are obsessed with emotional connection and the idea of publicness. They aspire to be generous and joyful," says Matt.

Today, scientific evidence suggests that specific design features can robustly predict visual stress, and that buildings in Seoul have become 30% more stressful over the past century, based on a sample of 78 buildings spanning five historical periods from the Late Joseon Dynasty to the present day.

All images provided by Heatherwick Studio

“The big challenge is translating that knowledge into what gets built,” says Matt. “In Yeouido, we’re working on a residential redevelopment of 576 homes, using warm materials and crafted forms.” On the ground floor, the design prioritises the human experience and experiments with undulating roof lines. “It feels special and gives something to everyone, whether you live in the complex or not.”

**NODEOL ISLAND PROJECT**

On the 21st of October last year, the groundbreaking ceremony for the transformation of the uninhabited Nodeol Island on the Han River took place. Commissioned by the Seoul Metropolitan Government, the winning design called ‘Soundscape’ aims to celebrate Korean music and create a new topography for people to explore and enjoy.

“Seoul always strikes me as a city that thrives on invention and emotion,” Matt says. “But people need some balance too, don’t they? Places where they can reconnect with each other and with themselves.”

The Studio’s central idea for the Nodeol Island project is to create exactly that: a mix of public space and natural beauty, culture and recreation, that is free and accessible to every citizen.

At ground level, there will be an art centre and a public beach. There vision is to have visitor spaces with recording studios, concert halls, a waterfront amphitheatre, a K-pop experience centre, a music cafe, an anechoic chamber and a karaoke bar.

“Seoul always strikes me as a city that thrives on invention and emotion.”

Hight above, there will be an elevated 1.25 km urban trail looping over a series of small islets that appear to hover in the air.

“We want to amplify all the things that make Nodeol Island different and inviting: the water’s edge, the sense of escape and the romance of the river, with sound central to the entire experience,” says Matt. “It should be the culture of Seoul expressed through music and landscape. A magical place for a great global city.”

The project is scheduled to open in 2028, and construction is occuring in phases to maintain continuous public access to the island.

# HEATHERWICK STUDIO

Founded by Thomas Heatherwick in London in 1994, Heatherwick Studio is a globally recognised design and architecture practice with a team of over 200 people. The studio is known for pushing the boundaries of design through a combination of engineering expertise, inventive use of materials, and cutting-edge technology — with a strong philosophy around integrating nature and social sustainability into its work.

## NOTABLE PROJECTS

UK Pavilion, Shanghai Expo (2010)
Olympic Cauldron, London 2012
New Routemaster Bus, London
Coal Drops Yard, King's Cross, London
Vessel, Hudson Yards, New York
Little Island, Hudson River, New York
Google Campus, California (with Bjarke Ingels Group)
Learning Hub, Nanyang Technological University, Singapore

## RECOMMENDED READ

Humanise - A Maker's Guide to Building Our World by Thomas Heatherwick. Penguin, 2023

SEOUL'S RETAIL IS NOT ONLY BRAVE IN ITS INTERIOR SPACE
PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT ITSELF. IN SEOUL, WE ARE ALWA
TRYING A NEW FLAVOUR, FORMULATION, COLOUR, OR MATE

# KEEPSAK

**LEE EUN SANG** LIMITED UNIQUE,
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**HARUHARU WONDER** ROSE
PDRN SOOTHING SERUM

**MAGPI**
MUGW

**RYU** WEST SEA SPIRIT CITRUS &
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**TAMBURINS** LEATHER W
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MILANO
XXV OLYMPIC WINTER GAMES
PARALYMPIC WINTER GAMES

# THE OLYMPIC MEDALS AND THE BUDDHIST MONK

As South Korea started to celebrate the wins of three Olympic medals in snowboarding, a story about a Buddhist monk and a snowboard competition sponsored by the largest Buddhist order of Korea surfaced.

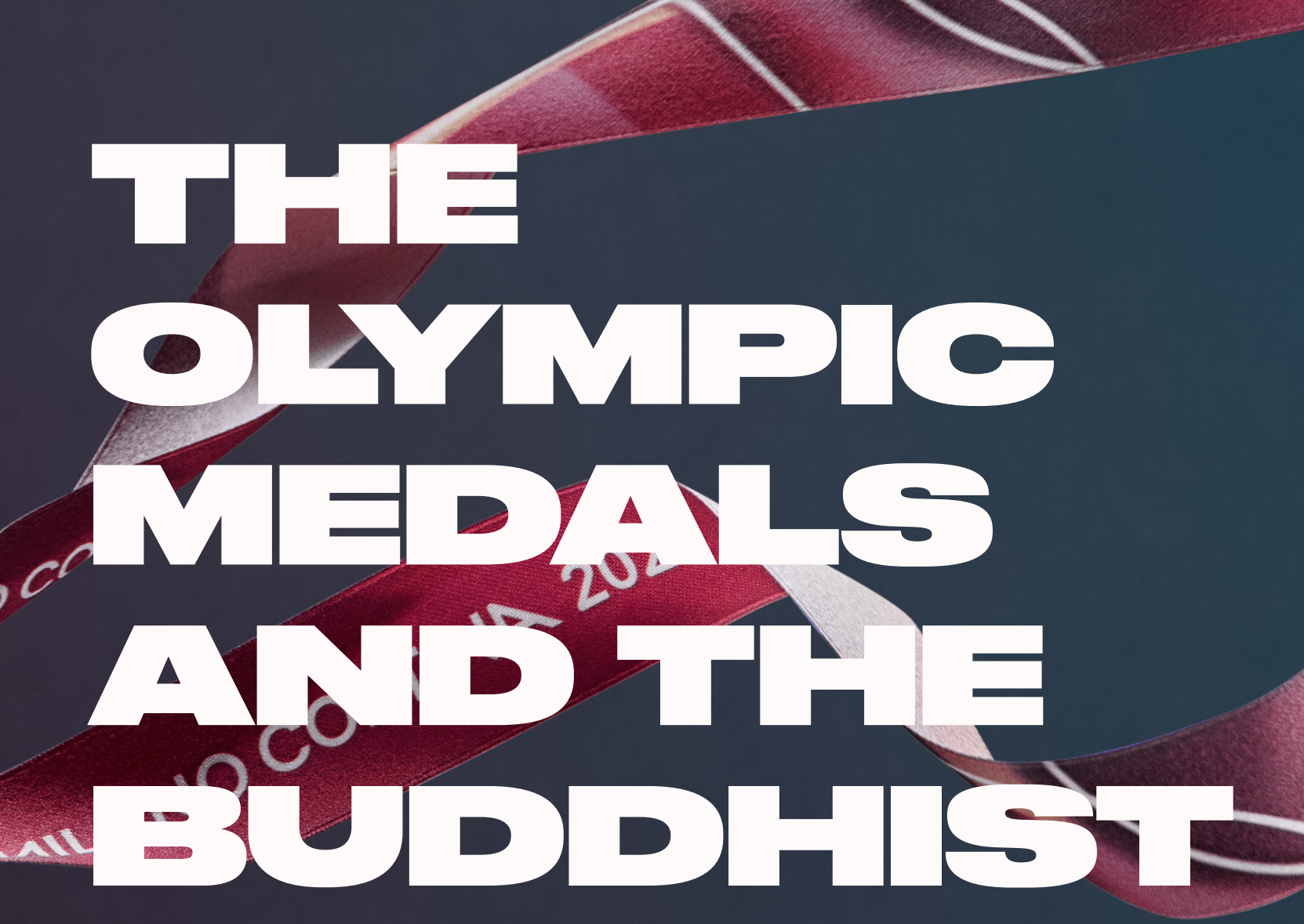

Image from Milano-Cortina Olympics' press portal

South Korea won three snowboarding Olympic medals in Milano Cortina: Choi Gaon took Gold in Women's halfpipe, Kim Sang-gyeom Silver in Men's Parallel Giant Slalom, and Yoo Seung-eun Bronze in Women's Big Air.

The success seemed to come out of nowhere. Since the sport's debut at the Nagano 1998 Olympics, Korea only won one other medal – at the PyeongChang 2018 Olympics, which then looked a little like a one-time fluke. Snowboarding has long been overlooked in Korea; the focus has been on ice sport,s given that the country even lacks a proper permanent training facility.

Venerable Hosan, now in his early sixties, to offer prayers for safety at a ski resort near Bongseon Temple. As a thank you, he received a lift pass. When visiting the resort, he started seeing something particular in snowboarders — a freedom he recognised:

"In Buddhism, too, we seek ultimate liberation from the cycle of birth and death," he said to Yonhap News Agency.

While learning to snowboard, he also learned that there was no infrastructure around the sport: little institutional support and media attention, no systematic training or high-quality competition, and athletes juggling part-time jobs alongside training.

# "Given Korea's conditions for sno
# that is nothing short of a miracle."

There is one common denominator for all four medals: all four athletes are Dharma Kids. All four are part of the Dalma Open Championship organised by the Jogye Order of Korean Buddhism, a competition organised by Venerable Hosan, abbot of Bongseon Temple in Namyangju, Gyeonggi Province.

In 1995, a ski resort asked

In 2003, he launched a competition offering prize money, using his own savings and support from monks at other temples. The event grew and became the largest international snowboard competition in Korea, with ranking points awarded by the International Ski and Snowboard Federation (FIS) for the World Cup.

Once PyeongChang was confirmed as the host of the 2018 Winter Olympic Games, the goal became to support young people with Olympic potential — and Lee Sang-ho won a Silver medal in Men's Parallel Giant Slalom. This became the starting point for further support and infrastructure: in 2022, Lotte established a ski and snowboard team, providing athletes with signing bonuses, training fees, and equipment. Athletes now spend over 200 days a year abroad to access training facilities.

"It was already amazing that she [Choi Gaon] became the first Korean to reach the halfpipe final, and then she won gold." Ven. Hosan said to Maeil Business Newspaper. "Given Korea's conditions for snow sports, that is nothing short of a miracle.

w sports,

**SOUTH KOREA OLYMPIC SNOWBOARDING MEDALS (ALL TIME)**

**2018 PYEONGCHANG**
Men's Parallel Giant Slalom
Lee Sang-ho, Silver

**2026 MILAN-CORTINA**
Women's Halfpipe
Choi Gaon, Gold

Men's Parallel Giant Slalom
Kim Sang-gyeom, Silver

Women's Big Air
Yoo Seung-eun, Bronze

# THE BUKCHON VILLAGE HOTEL

Across a cluster of restored hanoks in Jongno and Bukchon, IWA runs what it calls a “distributed village hotel” — a model in which the neighbourhood itself becomes the hotel. The lobby is a café down the alley. Dinner is where locals have been going for years. The room is a century-old hanok that someone has had the good sense to keep alive.

Each property has been carefully restored within the constraints of the heritage — floor heating under original timber, open-air baths in walled courtyards, stone tea tables carved from Goheung rock. The aesthetic sits somewhere between Joseon literati and contemporary Korean minimalism: unfamiliar, although warm, considered but never pretentious.

IWA also produces its own fragrance line, developed specifically to hold what they call "the scent of a space where time has gathered." Rooted in an Eastern sensibility — wood, stone, water, air — the scents are sold as a kind of portable memory of the stay.

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# THE PROPERTIES

**ANGILLSAGA** A 1929 hanok in Anguk-dong, steps from the Constitutional Court and the ghost of Bukchon's aristocratic past. Sky-ceiling outdoor bath, ink stone tea table, garden that earns its keep. Sleeps 5.

**IHOSSORAK** The smallest and most hidden of the four — a tucked-away Sogyeok-dong hanok built around 80-year-old wooden pillars, a round window, and a 6-pyeong courtyard with a white azalea and moss stones. Intimacy is the whole point. Sleeps 3.

**SASAROI** A ㄷ-shaped hanok facing Songhyeon Plaza, centred on a four-person indoor soaking tub with courtyard views. A kind of place where doing nothing together feels like an event. Sleeps 4.

**MUWOLGWAN** The most generous of the properties — two bedrooms, two bathrooms, a private jacuzzi annex, and walls that dissolve into full-width windows. Set beside a former Joseon royal villa, two minutes from Anguk Station. The one to book when the group is bigger and the occasion calls for it. Sleeps 10.

BOOKINGS iwaspace.com
PRODUCTS iwaspace-mall.com

All photographs provided by IWA

# PROTECTION A
# THE INTERNET'S
# TENDENCIES

**Korea's AI Basic Act is the first in its kind globally. The bill comes after a surge of deepfake crimes and intends to find the balance between protection and enablement.**

On 22 January this year, South Korea became the first country in the world to put a comprehensive national AI law into full legal effect. The law is formally titled the Basic Act on the Development of Artificial Intelligence and the Establishment of a Foundation for Trustworthiness. It runs to 43 articles across six chapters. The Act mandates watermarking of artificial intelligence–generated content, imposes risk–management obligations on high–impact systems, and requires major foreign technology companies to appoint local representatives in Korea.

"Seoul is betting that rules don't have to kill adoption, but legitimise it," Catherine Thorbecke writes in an opinion piece in Bloomberg.

> "Seoul is betting that rules don't have to kill adoption, but legitimise it."

Korea has seen one of the fastest AI surges since the post–ChatGPT era. Since October 2025, the use of generative AI in Korea has jumped over 80%, compared to 35% globally. The country ranks second in paying ChatGPT subscribers, behind only the US.

# GAINST
# S WORST

Photo by Zerotake on Unsplash

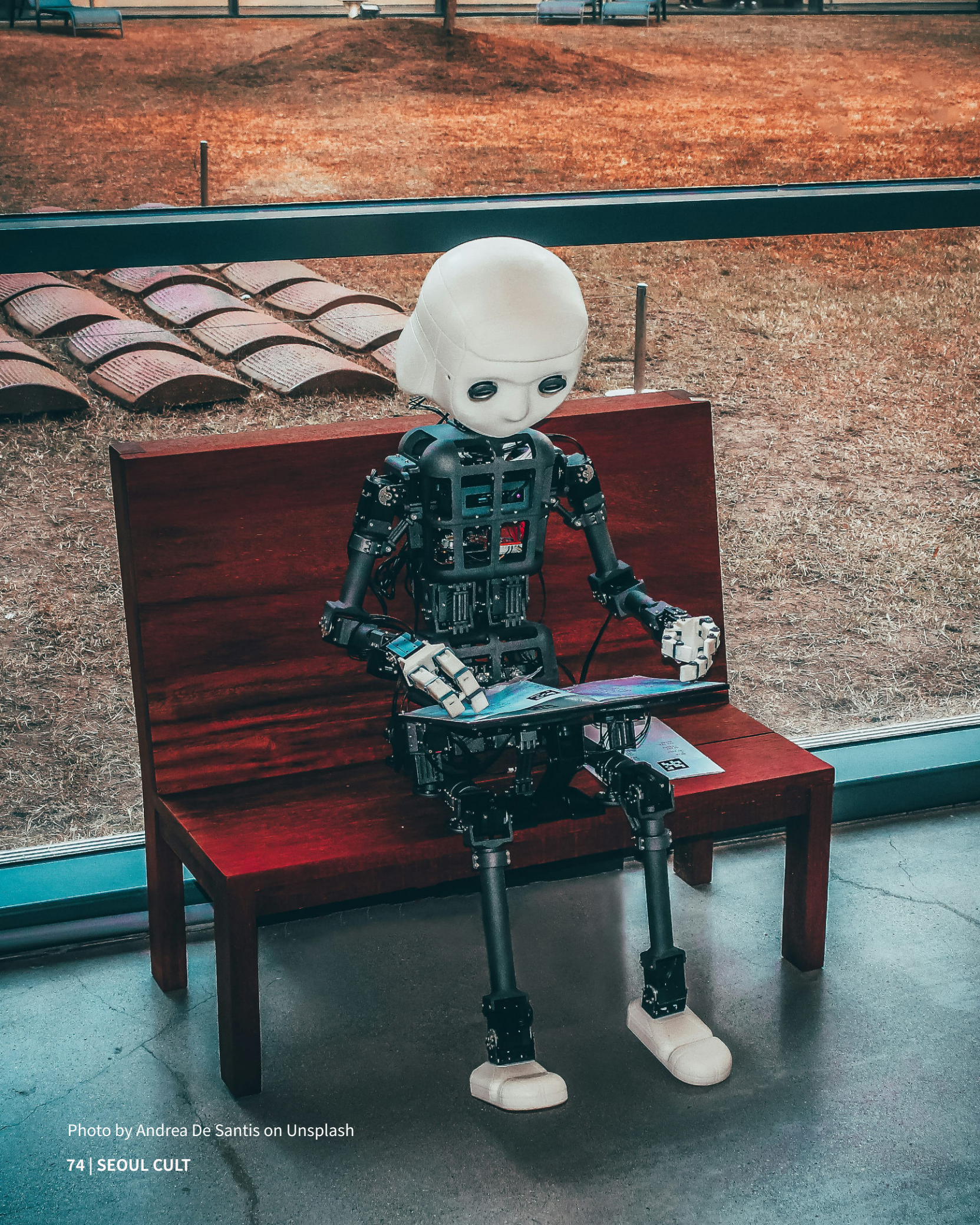

Photo by Andrea De Santis on Unsplash

“For decades, adopting new technology was basically linked to survival and growth. AI turns into a kind of FOMO — if I don’t learn this, and everybody else already has, I’m going to be left out,” says Kim Sejin, Associate Director at the Center for Korean Innovation and Competitiveness to POLITICO magazine.

## FOUR YEARS IN THE MAKING

South Korea’s first AI bill was introduced to the National Assembly in July 2020, but met criticism for favouring industry over citizens. Ultimately, 19 bills were merged through bipartisan agreement and passed in December 2024.

> "For decades, adopting new technology was basically linked to survival and growth."

The European Union adopts a risk-based model that emphasises preemptive controls. In contrast, the United States and the United Kingdom rely on sector-specific, market-driven regulation, while China implements a state-led industrial policy and service-specific directives. South Korea uses a flexible, principles-based framework emphasising trust-driven oversight. High-impact AI, defined as systems with considerable consequences for human life, safety, or rights in contexts such as healthcare, criminal investigations, transportation, financial screening, and education, needs a comprehensive risk assessment and clear documentation of decision-making procedures.

- Content generated by AI must carry watermarks or explicit disclosures
- Companies providing AI services must notify users that they are interacting with AI
- Extremely powerful AI models must submit a safety report, though the threshold is set so high that government officials recognise that no models currently operating in the world meet it
- Foreign companies must designate a domestic representative in Korea if they meet at least one of the three thresholds: global revenue of 1 trillion won, domestic revenue of 10 billion won, or an average of more than 1 million daily users in Korea

## PROTECTING CITIZENS FROM THE INTERNET'S WORST TENDENCIES

Korea became an ultra-connected country early. After the Asian financial crisis in 1997-98, the government prioritised broadband as an engine of economic recovery, and by the early 2000s, the country had the world's highest broadband penetration. In 2001, 57.3 of Korean home internet users were already on broadband, compared to just 11.1 per cent in the US, which was second in the world at the time. In early 2025, South Korea had 97.4 per cent population internet penetration and 100% household connectivity. The country has ranked first on the UN ICT Development Index since its launch, and 97.6 per cent of the population owns a smartphone — the highest rate in the world.

Following an online bullying incident that led to the suicide of a prominent Korean actress, the Korean government amended the Communications Network Act. The new law required website and online game operators to implement a real-name registration system. The logic was safety and trust: if people had to identify themselves, harassment would diminish. The result was the creation of vast centralised databases of citizens' real identities, linked to their online activity.

In 2011, hackers compromised many of those databases. The Constitutional Court struck down the "world's first" real-name requirement as unconstitutional in 2012. Even after the ruling, identity verification tied to a national resident registration number has stayed standard practice across domestic internet services, financial accounts, mobile contracts and major portals such as Naver and Kakao.

> "The law isn't perfect, but it's intended to change without stifling innovation."

The AI Basic Act came into effect with the same intention: to protect citizens from the internet's worst tendencies. Deepfakes have become an issue globally, but according to the identity protection firm Security Hero, Korea accounts for over 53 per cent of all deepfake pornography victims. In 2024, an investigation exposed massive networks of Telegram chatrooms creating and distributing AI-generated sexual imagery of women and girls.

## WHY DO WE HAVE TO BE THE FIRST TO DO THIS?

On the day the legislation came into effect, a support desk was opened at the

Korea AI Software Industry Association to help companies comply with the new law. By the end of the month, 172 consultations had been received. The most common question, accounting for more than half of the questions, concerned the transparency obligation: How exactly does a company tell its users that AI was used to produce something?

The confusion was expected. A survey run by the nonprofit Startup Alliance of 1010 domestic AI startups in December 2025 found that 98 per cent had not established systems to comply with the AI Basic Act.

"Startups struggle with time and funding for technology development," said Lim Jeongwook, co-representative of Startup Alliance. Now, they have to ensure their work complies with the law, which may delay innovation. In an interview with Reuters, he was more blunt: "There's a bit of resentment. Why do we have to be first?"

## THE WATERMARK PROBLEM

The requirement of watermarks — visible or invisible digital markers identifying AI-produced content — is one of the most concrete provisions of the law. However, it is also difficult to enforce.

For viewers to more easily recognise as artificial, such as animation or stylised digital art, invisible watermarks are enough. For deepfake content that closely resembles real people or events, a clear or visible watermark is required. For the video, the watermark must persist throughout. For audio, the annotation must appear at the beginning.

However, a large share of deepfake content circulating in Korea is created using overseas applications that fall outside the law's jurisdiction, and watermark-removal tools are widely available.

Alice Oha, a computer science professor at the Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology, said, "The law isn't perfect, but it's intended to change without stifling innovation."

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# BOUQUET COLLECTION LAUNCH

In January, Gentle Monster launched its 2026 Bouquet Collection with a campaign film co-directed by artists FKA twigs and Jordan Hemingway. The film is set to an unreleased track by FKA twigs, and it captures the energy of a flower in bloom.

The collection is inspired by the delicate architecture of plant stems and reimagines these organic details in a distinctive eyewear line.

To launch the collection, Gentle Monster created immersive pop-up spaces in six cities worldwide. Each was filled with blossoms, welcoming visitors to Gentle Monster's imaginative world, the brand said in a press release.

Each space in full bloom is a dreamlike encounter. Towering floral sculptures in bold hues and dramatic textures encircle a chrome statue.

### WHERE TO SEE THE COLLECTION

Gentle Monster New York, Haus Nowhere Seoul, Haus Nowhere Dosan, Haus Nowhere Shanghai, Gentle Monster Beijing Taikoo Li, Gentle Monster Tokyo Aoyama, Gentle Monster Bangkok Emquartier

GENTLE MONSTER
GENTLE MONSTER

All photos provided by Gentle Monster

# WHAT WE ARE WATCHING

## THE ART OF SARAH

**Series - Streaming on Netflix**

The eight-episode K-drama thriller, that debuted in February 2026, quickly climbed to number one globally. The series follows Sarah Kim, a woman who constructed a fraudulent identity as a high-society luxury brand executive, and the detective who unravels the increasingly shifting story behind her mysterious death.

## NO OTHER CHOICE

**Movie - Streaming on Netflix**

Park Chan-wook's black comedy thriller opened to a nine-minute standing ovation at Venice before becoming one of the most talked-about Korean films of the year. The film follows Man-su, a devoted paper company employee of 25 years who, after an abrupt layoff, devises a ruthless plan to secure a new job — by systematically eliminating every one of his competitors.

## THE PHILOSOPHER'S KITCHEN JEONG KWAN

**Documentary - Streaming on Netflix**

The two-episode documentary series arrived on Netflix in February 2026, years after Jeong Kwan first captivated the world through her Chef's Table profile. The series follows the Buddhist nun and philosopher chef as she moves through the rhythms of temple life at Chunjinam Hermitage — growing, fermenting, foraging — tracing the past, present, and future of Korean temple cuisine through the quiet conviction that food, made with pure intention, is itself a path to enlightenment.

LACHA

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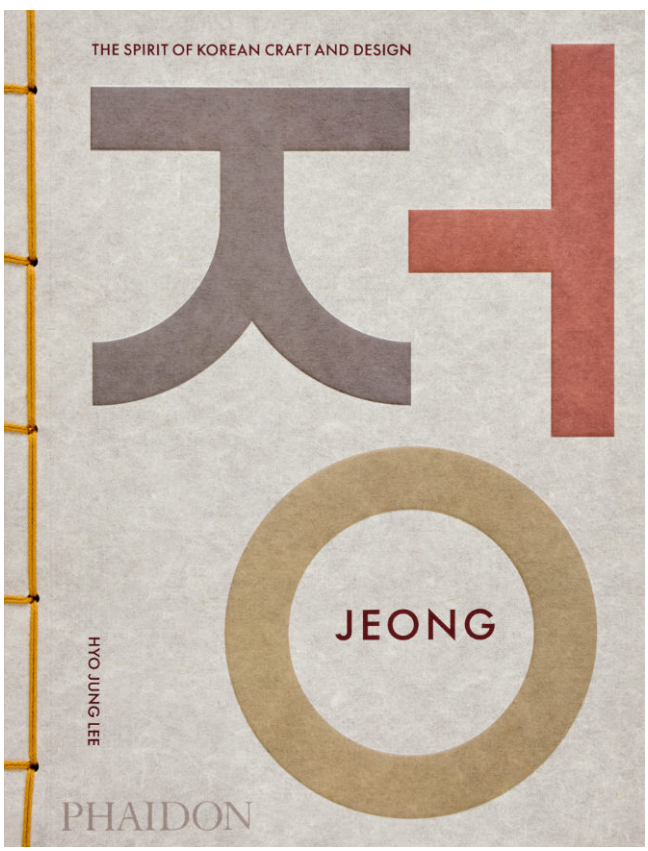
# JEONG

## THE SPIRIT OF KOREAN CRAFT AND DESIGN

Phaidon's Jeong is the first book to map the full breadth of Korean design. It is authored by London-based Korean graphic designer Hyo Jung Lee at Pentagram. The book covers 3,000 years of Korean design through 175 objects. These range from anonymous hand-thrown bowls and woven baskets to Kwangho Lee's nylon rope armchair and Dong Jun Kim's porcelain moon jar.

The organising principle is the concept of jeong: the Korean idea of connection, empathy, and devotion between maker, material, and user. This quality turns an everyday object into something that carries memory. Museum pieces from the V&A, the Leeum, and the Onyang Folk Museum appear alongside contemporary works without hierarchy. This illustrates how jeong carries through time.




**PUBLISHER**
Phaidon

**AUTHOR**
Hyo Jung Lee, with essays by Teo Yang, Beth McKillop and J Kathryn Hong

**PUBLICATION DATE**
March 2026

**ABOUT THE AUTHOR**
Born in Korea and based in London, Hyo Jung Lee is a graphic designer at Pentagram. In 2020, she founded the Korean Craft and Design digital platform. She also launched a retail site stocking Korean artisanal products and runs a series of supper clubs in London.

Moon jar, Joseon Dynasty. Image credit: National Museum of Korea (page 186)

Bangjja yugi bowl. Image credit: photo by Gangjinju (page 25) bronzeware

Onggi. Image credit: © Hyunwoo Min (page 38) clay, sand

Daybed, Hyung Suk Jo, 2012. Image credit: Arumjigi Foundation, © Guru Visual (page 141) ash wood, fabric

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